In January 1991, following Military Intelligence's presentation of its annual intelligence assessment to the government, we were asked by the prime minister to address, in the Mossad's presentation, not only our assessment for the year but also our evaluation from a multiyear perspective. This was an unexpected assignment. MI's assessment was presented on a Friday, and our assessment was due to be presented the following Sunday. We had only the weekend to prepare. I made two decisions: I would put aside the assessment that had been put together by the research department, and I myself would present the product that we would prepare over the weekend. But before I get to that, here is a bit of background on how the idea to establish a strategic research team within the Mossad's research department, whose task it is to deal with central issues on Israel's national security agenda from a long-term (five to ten years) perspective, came about.

The Yom Kippur War was a defining event in the short history of the State of Israel. The shock waves caused by this war have not yet subsided. The IDF and the Israeli intelligence community were among the first victims of the war; the Agranat Commission, which investigated the period preceding the outbreak of the war and its first three days (October 6–8, 1973), made several decisions that had a significant influence on the intelligence community.

The first main decision was the addition of a new dimension to the concept of authority and responsibility that had not existed until then—sanctions. The head of Military Intelligence, who had erred in his assessments, was fired from his post, and it was determined that sanctions would be the law going forward and the new norm in the intelligence community.

The second main decision was that the method that had been adopted, according to which there was only one body conducting national assessments—Military Intelligence—would be amended to become a pluralistic system of assessment, whereby the Mossad would establish its first research department. This meant that the Mossad would go from being an intelligence-gathering and special operations agency to an intelligence-gathering, special operations, and research and assessment agency—a dramatic change. The Foreign Ministry would upgrade its research body, and the Shin Bet would also establish its own research department that would cover its areas of responsibility.